

Stains of Fear

Mojtaba Zarghampour
Mahdi Hosseingholi

INT. STUDIO - NIGHT

A CLOSE-UP of a computer screen. Indistinct text and images. Slowly, the camera ZOOMS OUT, revealing the contents on the screen. JONAS, a gaunt man in his late 30s, makes the final adjustments and shuts down the system. He checks the time: 1:00 AM. He pulls up the train schedule— the last train leaves in two minutes. He rushes to get ready. The studio is nearly empty, containing only a table and a laptop. A large window faces another building, where a single lit window is visible. JONAS hurriedly puts on his coat, exits, and locks the door.

EXT. TRAM STATION - NIGHT

JONAS runs towards the tram but misses it. He checks the schedule on his phone—the next one isn't until 5:00 AM. He returns to his building, noticing that the entrance door is slightly open. He hesitates, glancing around, then steps inside. Before re-entering the studio, he pauses and pulls out a cigarette. As he takes out his lighter, it slips from his hands and falls to the lower floor. JONAS descends to retrieve the lighter but suddenly hears a faint sound from above. He looks up. Through the window of the opposite unit, he sees a dim light. Alarmed, he quickly ascends the stairs. Reaching the hallway, he finds the opposite apartment now dark. He walks up to the door and presses his ear against it. Silence.

JONAS

Peter?

No response. He knocks. Still nothing. He pulls out his phone, takes a photo of the window, then calls PETER. No answer. JONAS moves cautiously toward his studio. Unthinkingly, he pushes the door open— He stops abruptly. He had locked the door. But now, it's unlocked.

INT. STUDIO - NIGHT

JONAS enters, leaving the door slightly open. He scans the room. Everything seems normal. He shuts and locks the door. Seated at his desk, he stares at the opposite apartment. The window across the way appears to be molding over. Suddenly, a faint THUMP against his own window. He jolts awake—he had dozed off.

Looking out, he sees nothing unusual. He leans forward to check below—

No one is there.

He sits back down and slowly raises his eyes. The opposite apartment window is now lit again.

A SHADOWED FIGURE is staring at him.

A KNOCK at the studio door.

JONAS

Wär isch do?

Silence.

Another KNOCK. Louder.

JONAS (CONT'D) (shouting)

Wär isch do?!

Silence.

Then—a sound of retreating footsteps.

JONAS looks back to the opposite apartment—the window is still lit, but the figure is gone.

Then—a sudden rush of footsteps toward his door. A LOUD POUNDING.

JONAS stands, heart pounding.

JONAS (CONT'D)

Was willsch vo mir?!

Silence.

The footsteps recede again.

Then—a CHARGE toward the door, a THUMP.

At the same time, his phone VIBRATES. He jolts awake.

Startled, he fumbles for it—PETER is calling.

JONAS (CONT'D) (into phone)

Peter?

PETER (V.O.)

Hey. Bisch ufm Strich?

JONAS

Hmm?!

PETER (V.O.)

Du hesch mir aglüte?

JONAS

(trying to steady himself) Jo.. Bisch du do?

PETER (V.O.)

Wo?

JONAS

In dim Büro.

PETER (V.O.)

Nei ich bi dehei. Wieso?

JONAS (swallows hard)

Nüt. Ich bi im Büro gsi. Ha öppis ghört. Ha dänkt du
bisch villicht do.

PETER (V.O.)

Du bisch immer no im Büro?

JONAS

Jo. Tram verpasst.

PETER (V.O.)

Also schloofsch dört?

JONAS

Jo. Kumm nüm hei bis morn.

PETER (V.O.)

Alles klar. Sig vorsichtig.

A long pause.

JONAS

Wieso?

PETER (V.O.)

Gester het mr dr Andre nomol drvo vrzellt.
Schiinbar sin öfter mol Zigüüner dört.

(Unrecognizable noises)

Isch lang läär gstande.

JONAS

Wart schnäll, ha kei guets Netz..

He paces.

PETER (V.O.)

Ich meins ärnst, das isch kei so sichers Quartier.
Du weisch was füre Art Mensche dört wohne.

JONAS

Jo.. Ich weiss.

PETER (V.O.)

Mr probiere öppis.

(A moment of silence)

Ghörsch mi?

JONAS

Jo.

PETER (V.O.)

Weisch was, ich kumm und hol di, sobald d Nina mitm
Auto zrugg isch.

JONAS

Nei, dasch nid nötig.

PETER (V.O.)

Doch! Es isch gefährlich! Unterschätz es nid.

JONAS

Mir hän nüt wärtvolls do.

PETER (V.O.)

Es goht nid um was mir hän. Es goht um s Büro
sälber.

JONAS

Okay.. Denn bis spöter

PETER (V.O.)

Bis spöter. Bhalt di Handy in dr nöchi.

After the call is cut off, JONAS goes to his desk and notices that the office across from him is now lit. He takes his camera out of his bag, assembles the tripod, mounts the camera on it, and points it toward the window of the office across the way before switching it on. We see him adjusting the camera's frame, then a close-up shot of the opposite window, which JONAS stares at for a while. He places his hand on the shutter like a hunter ready to shoot. Suddenly, he notices something that looks like a ghostly shadow. He

reacts instantly and snaps a photo. Lifting his head, he looks at the window—nothing there. He checks through the camera's view again—still nothing.

He turns back and checks the photo he's just taken, but the camera shows no image. He switches the camera off and on, removes and reinserts the memory card—still nothing. He then connects the camera to his laptop to see the photo. When he opens the file, he's surprised by what he sees: strange spots in the image that look like some kind of mold, vaguely similar to what he had been working on but still different.

At that moment, his phone rings. It's PETER.

JONAS (into phone)
Peter?

STATIC fills the line.

JONAS (CONT'D)
Hallo?

PETER (V.O.) (Suddenly)
Ghörsch mi?

JONAS
Jetzt, jo.

PETER (V.O.)
Alles okay?

JONAS
Jo.. Nei. Di Büroliecht isch ah.

PETER (V.O.)
Has wohrschinlich vergässe abzschalte.

JONAS
Es isch vorhär nid ah gsi.

PETER (V.O.)
Villicht heschs dr iiblidet.

JONAS
Es isch nid ah gsi. Es isch ah gange.. denn ab..
denn widr ah.

PETER (V.O.)
Ich verstand nid ganz was du meinsch.

JONAS
Ich ka dir e Föteli schicke.

PETER (V.O.) (suspicious) (his tone changes)
Du machsch Föteli?

JONAS hesitates.

JONAS
Nonig. Aber ich könnt eins mache.

PETER (V.O.) (softly) (in his previous tone)
Ah, okay.
Ich ha dir eigentlich nur welle sage dass Nina jetzt
do isch.
Ich bi unterwägs. Pack dini Sache.

JONAS
Die sin packt.

JONAS zooms into the photo. Takes a closer look at the details of
the distortions.

PETER (V.O.)
Was gsehsch?

JONAS (shocked)
Hmm?!

PETER (V.O.)
Hesch mi verstande?

JONAS
Mhm! Lüt mr ah wennd do bisch.

PETER (V.O.)
Machs guet!

JONAS stares at the photo for a while, then suddenly remembers
something. He quickly opens the gallery on his phone and pulls up
the last photo he took. He zooms in. A small mark appears in this
photo as well, but in both images, there is no sign of another
person.
He transfers the photo to his laptop for a closer look. Adjusting
the image settings, he enhances the details, making the stain more

visible. He places the two photos side by side—both contain the same mold-like spots.

Confused and unsettled, he pulls his gaze away from the laptop screen and stares at the window across from him.

A noise comes from the kitchen. Slowly, he walks toward it and reaches the doorway.

Suddenly, a shadow appears.

JONAS immediately slams the door shut.

JONAS

Wär isch do? Was wilsch vo mir!?

There is no response.

JONAS locks the door and waits for a while. He presses his ear against it—silence. Slowly, he steps away from the door.

His phone rings. He turns back to the room to answer it. He picks up the call. It's PETER

JONAS (nervously)

Jä?

PETER (V.O.)

Du dörfsch kei Angst ha. Das machts nur schlimmer.

JONAS

Was?

PETER (V.O.)

Di Zuestand. Angst macht di kaputt.

Schnuuf tief ih und sitz ane.

JONAS hesitates briefly, goes to his office, and sits down. As soon as he sits, PETER begins to speak:

PETER (V.O.)

Guet, stell di Handy uf Lutsprächer und legs ufe Tisch.

JONAS puts the phone on speaker and sets it on the table.

PETER (V.O.)

Okay. Jetzt sag mr was du gsehsch.

JONAS

Ich ha nid vill gseh.. Wieso frogsch du das??

PETER (V.O.)

Es isch offensichtlich dass du Angst hesch.

Ich will nur s beste für di.
Du bisch e guete Fründ.

JONAS stays silent.

PETER (V.O.)
Also.. Verzell.

JONAS
Es fühlt sich ah als wär öpper im Büro.

PETER (V.O.)
Hesch abgschlosse?

JONAS hesitates before answering.

JONAS
Jo.
PETER (V.O.)
Also..

JONAS (after a brief pause)
Ich ha abgschlosse. Aber denn öppis in dr Kuchi
ghört.

PETER (V.O.)
Villicht ischs s Bränneli gsi.

JONAS
Ich has gseh..

PETER (V.O.)
Wie hets usgeh?

JONAS
E Schatte.

We hear PETER take a deep breath and exhale heavily.

PETER (V.O.)
Das isch nüt. Ich bi unterwägs.
Ha kei Benzin me ka. Bi biz z spoot.
Heb sorg.

JONAS
Ich weiss nid was..

Mid-sentence, the call cuts off. JONAS looks back at his laptop screen, staring at it for a while. Then he goes over to the camera, studies its screen for a moment, and snaps a photo. He transfers the photo to the laptop; the same strange spots appear again. He takes another photo—same result. He does this once more. Finally, he gazes at the photos for a while, then lifts his head and looks at the window across from him. We see the shadow has reappeared. For a moment, the image seems moldy. He rubs his eyes, then looks at the shadow again. Slowly, he reaches for the camera and takes another picture. He checks it; it's dark. He brings up the ISO on his camera and then takes another picture. Still unclear. It's extremely dark with mold-like distortions. He repeats this process two more times; the last photo is brighter but heavily overrun with mold-like patterns, so much that nothing is recognisable. Still staring at the opposite window, his phone rings. Without shifting his gaze, he answers:

JONAS
Bisch do?

PETER (V.O.)
Ganz nooch. Mach dr keini Sorge.

A moment of silence.

PETER (V.O.)
Nüm wiit. Muesch nur no biz warte. Kasch das?

JONAS
Ka ich was?

PETER (V.O.)
Kasch warte?

JONAS
Ich glaub scho.

PETER (V.O.)
Isch es no dört?

JONAS
Jo..

PETER (V.O.)
Gspürschs?

JONAS (more firmly)
Jo..

PETER takes a deep breath.

PETER (V.O.)
Was fühl'sch?

JONAS
Angst.

PETER (V.O.)
Vor was hesch Angst.

JONAS
Em Änd.

PETER (V.O.)
S Änd isch nid immer schlimm.
Isch das, was du gsehsch unheimlich?

JONAS (long pause)
Nei.

PETER (V.O.)
Was gsehsch denn?

JONAS describes the moldy image.

PETER (V.O.)
Nei.. Ich mein was gsehsch?

JONAS (long pause)
S Änd.

The shadow fades from the window across the way, stepping out of the frame. Soft footsteps approach until they reach us.

PETER (voice nearby)
Kei Angst. Ich bi do.

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